MERCY'S ANATOMY

Season 2, Episode 9

"Thanks for the Memories"

Episode 2x09. The counterpart of *Grey's Anatomy* 2x09. Narrator: Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock

In-story dates: Thursday, November 24, 2005 (Thanksgiving Day), 4:58 AM through 11:59 PM

Script: Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag. 41 scenes. Standard: MA-009

Depends on MA-001 through MA-011 and episodes 1x01-2x08

EPISODE PDF PACKAGE (MA-009 §6): 1. Title page and cast (with ages on Thursday, November 24, 2005). 2. Script. 3. Media Companion. 4. Continuity Sheet.

Cast in Order of Appearance (Ages on Thursday, November 24, 2005)

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Dr. Raven Ellison	Surgical Intern (day off, cooking)	Dec 3, 1979	25
Dr. Amond Baker	Surgical Intern	Feb 10, 1979	26
Dr. Robert Bullock	Chief of Cardiothoracic Surgery	Feb 10, 1956	49
Dr. Natasha Donohue	Chief of Surgery	Jun 2, 1958	47
Lillian Divine	Harmony's mother	Feb 14, 1952	53
Howard Divine	Harmony's father; MTA bus operator	Aug 30, 1950	55
Nurse Gloria Pettiford	Head ER Nurse	Apr 14, 1952	53
Dr. Harmony Divine	Surgical Intern	Jun 19, 1979	26
Dr. Arianna Cummings	Surgical Intern	Oct 25, 1979	26
Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock	Surgical Intern (narrator)	Jan 5, 1979	26
Dr. Esther Smilley	Surgical Intern	Sep 20, 1979	26
Dr. Bryce Kennerly	Surgical Intern (on probation)	Jun 11, 1978	27
Dr. Elxa Bullock	Surgical Resident (29 weeks pregnant)	Aug 29, 1977	28
Dr. Isaiah Crump	Chief of Pediatric Surgery	Mar 11, 1944	61
Desmond Royster (new)	Patient: acute appendicitis	Feb 19, 1997	8
Shonda Royster (new)	Desmond's mother; MTA station agent	Jun 2, 1974	31
Winston Teague	Patient: LVAD, discharged	Jan 22, 1947	58
Pauline Teague	Winston's wife	Sep 30, 1950	55
Dr. Victor Donohue	Founder, Victor Donohue Foundation; Marc's grandfather	May 30, 1933	72
Dr. Clayton Hartwell	Fetal Surgeon (on call, L&D)	Mar 3, 1971	34
Corinne Smilley (V.O.)	Esther's mother	Jul 22, 1948	57
Deacon Theodore 'Teddy' Pritchard (new)	Patient: Boerhaave syndrome	Apr 9, 1946	59
Hazel Pritchard (new)	Teddy's wife	Jan 30, 1948	57
Leon Fairley (new)	Patient: turkey-fryer burns	Jul 16, 1958	47
Duane (new)	Leon's brother-in-law	Mar 5, 1961	44
Augustin Toussaint (on-screen debut)	Camille's father; displaced New Orleans hotelier	Feb 9, 1941	64
Dr. Camille Toussaint	Orthopedic Resident	Jul 21, 1976	29
Hattie 'Miss Hattie' Lomax	Cafeteria	Mar 3, 1945	60
Dr. Horace Whitlow	Chief of Medicine	Sep 19, 1949	56

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Dr. Solomon Fenwick (V.O.)	Amond's stepfather	Mar 21, 1948	57
Dr. Grace Bullock (on-screen debut)	Harvard Medical School student; Marc's sister	Apr 12, 1981	24
Mother Viola Sturdivant (new)	Patient: food bolus airway obstruction	Sep 12, 1921	84
Lorna Ellison (V.O., new)	Raven's mother	Mar 14, 1961	44
Josephine 'Grandma Jo' Bullock (V.O.)	Marc's paternal grandmother	Jan 19, 1931	74

Also appearing: two EMTs, Viola Sturdivant's granddaughter, a fluoroscopy tech, L&D; and CVICU nurses, a scrub nurse, Victor's driver, and Jerry and Ronnie Divine (off-screen). Mentioned: Dr. Joan Mercer, Claudette and V.J. Donohue, Russell Jeffries (by phone), Dr. Lowery (in Maryland), Malcolm Sloan, Lucius Donohue, Aunt Clarice and Dr. Yolanda Fitch.

COLD OPEN

1 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - PRE-DAWN
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - THANKSGIVING DAY - 4:58 AM

Every light is on. A twenty-two-pound turkey sits in a brining bucket in the sink. Three cookbooks lie open on the counter, weighed down with cans of evaporated milk. A legal pad is taped to the cabinet: "MENU," then twenty-one items, each with a time beside it. Raven (25), in a bonnet and an apron that reads "KISS THE COOK (DON'T)," chops celery at a speed that alarms her.

Amond (26) shuffles in, in a Stanford sweatshirt, squinting at the legal pad.

AMOND
(reading)
"5:15 AM, cornbread for the dressing. 5:40, sweet potatoes, first boil." (beat) Raven. There's a line that says "6:30, panic."

RAVEN
(not looking up)
It's scheduled so it doesn't spread.

MARC (V.O.)
Doctors are trained to remember everything.

RAVEN
(chopping)
My grandmother made Thanksgiving for forty people in Yamacraw Village. One oven, one burner that worked. (beat) Victor Donohue is coming to this house today, Amond. (beat) The Chief. The Chief of Cardio. Harvard Grace. (beat) I'm making it for eleven. I have four burners. (beat) I can do this.

AMOND
(beat, pouring coffee)
You know he's just a man, right? He eats food. Like a person.

RAVEN
(stopping, knife in the air)
He has a building named after him.

AMOND
(beat)
I'll peel potatoes.

MARC (V.O.)
Drug doses, nerve roots, the order of the branches of the aorta.

2 INT. NATASHA AND ROBERT'S BROWNSTONE - RIVERSIDE DRIVE - KITCHEN - PRE-DAWN
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 5:31 AM

A long, elegant kitchen with copper pots. Robert (49), in a cardigan with his sleeves rolled to the elbow, kneads dough with surgical precision. An index card leans against the flour canister in shaky cursive: "JO'S ROLLS." Natasha (47), in a silk robe, watches from the doorway with her tea.

NATASHA
(beat)
You haven't made your mother's rolls since 1999.

ROBERT
(kneading)
Daddy's funeral. (beat) Thirty-six rolls. Nobody ate them.

NATASHA
(crossing to him)
Robert. (beat) You're nervous.

ROBERT
(beat)
I've cracked open two thousand chests. (beat) Today I'm walking into my son's house as his father, in front of people who spent five months thinking his father drove a bus. (beat) And your father will be there in a three-piece suit, judging my rolls.

NATASHA
(smiling, laying her hand on his back)
Daddy doesn't judge rolls. (beat) He judges men. (beat) Your rolls will be fine.

MARC (V.O.)
But nobody tells you that what you actually remember of a life has nothing to do with medicine.

Robert stops kneading. He looks at the index card, at his mother's handwriting.

MARC (V.O.)
You remember who was at the table.

END OF COLD OPEN

ACT ONE

3 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - AMBULANCE BAY - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 6:38 AM

A cold, windy gray morning. A Ford Econoline van from "DIVINE FAMILY CATERING (NOT A BUSINESS)" is double-parked in the ambulance bay. LILLIAN DIVINE (53), round, radiant, in a church hat and a down coat, directs the unloading like a field marshal. HOWARD DIVINE (55), Harmony's

father, in an MTA jacket, carries a stack of foil pans taller than his head. He coughs, a deep, wet cough, and keeps walking.

Gloria (53) comes out through the automatic doors with her hands on her hips.

GLORIA
Lillian Divine. (beat) It's not even seven.

LILLIAN
(handing her a pan)
Gloria Pettiford. Turkey, ham, collards, mac and cheese, candied yams. Two sweet potato pies for the night shift, one for you. (beat) Nobody in my baby's hospital works a holiday on vending-machine crackers.

Harmony (26) runs out, mortified, in scrubs.

HARMONY
Mama. (beat) Mama, this is an ambulance bay.

LILLIAN
(kissing her on both cheeks)
And the ambulances will go around, Baby Girl.

Howard sets the pans down on a gurney and coughs again, hard, into his elbow. Harmony turns.

HARMONY
(sharp)
Daddy.

HOWARD
(waving it off, big smile)
It's the cold.

HARMONY
(beat)
You have a nodule, Daddy. Six millimeters. The CT is due in December. (beat) Did you schedule it?

HOWARD
(beat)
December eighth. (beat) At Jamaica Hospital. Your mother made the call. I was standing right there.

LILLIAN
(firmly)
He was standing right there.

Harmony looks at her father. He winks, picks up another stack of pans, and carries them through the doors. She watches him go a moment too long.

4 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - INTERNS' LOCKER ROOM - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 6:54 AM

A skeleton holiday crew. Arianna (26) sits on the bench in scrubs with Raven's color-coded flashcards fanned out like a poker hand. Marc (26) and Esther (26) change at opposite ends. Kennerly (27) eats a granola bar alone. Harmony comes in smelling of collard greens.

ARIANNA
(reading a card, muttering)
"Most common cause of..." (beat, to Marc) Is your grandfather really helping Raven cook?

MARC
(pulling on his scrub top)
He called last night and asked what time she wanted him. (beat) She said, "Seven a.m., Dr. Donohue," and then hung up and lay on the kitchen floor for ten minutes.

HARMONY
(opening her locker)
I invited Camille. (beat) And her father.

Everyone turns.

HARMONY
(beat)
He lost everything in New Orleans. He's on a cousin's couch in Canarsie. (beat) Nobody should be alone on Thanksgiving.

ARIANNA
Does her father know you're...

HARMONY
(closing the locker)
I'm a friend from work. (beat) That's what he knows.

Esther, lacing her shoes, glances at Harmony with a flicker of recognition, then at Marc. Kennerly listens without looking up.

MARC
(to Esther, carefully)
There's room at the table. (beat) Raven said to tell you. (beat) Clayton too.

ESTHER
(beat)
Clayton's on call for L&D. (beat) I'm off at two. I'm making a turkey breast in Brooklyn Heights, and I'm calling my mother.

MARC
(nodding)
Okay.

ESTHER
(beat, at the door)
Tell Raven thank you.

5 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - NURSES' STATION - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 7:06 AM

A paper turkey with handprint feathers is taped to the counter. Elxa (28), 29 weeks pregnant, sits on a tall stool with her clipboard on her belly. She's running the service alone, and she looks it.

ELXA
Holiday rules. Lowery's in Maryland. Half the attendings are in Westchester. (beat) That leaves me, Crump until noon, Robert until three, Graves on call from his couch, and Clayton in L&D. (beat) Bullock, Smilley: general, with me. Cummings: Crump, peds. Divine: Ortho in the ER, Dr. Toussaint's waiting for you. Baker: Cardio. Kennerly: ER.

MARC
Raven?

ELXA
(beat)
Ellison traded two weekends for today off. (beat) To cook. (beat) For my grandfather. (beat) Whose idea was that?

Nobody answers.

ELXA
(beat)
Everybody's out by four if nobody's dying. (beat) If somebody's dying, nobody leaves. (beat) Happy Thanksgiving. Go.

The interns disperse. Elxa shifts on the stool and presses a hand to the side of her belly. Just for a second.

6 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - PEDIATRIC BAY - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 7:48 AM

DESMOND ROYSTER (8), curled on his side in Spider-Man pajamas, his face gray. His mother SHONDA ROYSTER (31), a MetroCard station agent still in uniform, rubs his back. Dr. Isaiah Crump (61), in a bow tie with tiny turkeys on it, presses gently on the boy's right lower quadrant. Arianna stands beside him.

CRUMP
Young man, does it hurt here? (beat) Or here?

DESMOND
(whimpering)
There. (beat) And when the car went over a bump.

CRUMP
(to Arianna)
Dr. Cummings. The bump.

ARIANNA
Peritoneal irritation. (beat) Fever of thirty-eight-four, white count sixteen, pain that started around the belly button last night and moved to the right lower quadrant. (beat) Acute appendicitis.

CRUMP
(beat)
Alvarado score?

ARIANNA
(beat)
Eight.

CRUMP
Most common organism in a perforated appendix?

ARIANNA
(beat, instantly)
E. coli and Bacteroides fragilis.

CRUMP
(beat, pleased)
Why are you looking at me like that?

ARIANNA
(beat)
That's a boards question, sir.

CRUMP
(adjusting his bow tie)
Everything is a boards question, Dr. Cummings. (beat) The boards are just a sick child who sits very still. (to Shonda) Mrs. Royster, your son needs his appendix out this morning. (beat) Dr. Cummings and I will be very careful with him.

DESMOND
(weak)
Do I still get turkey?

CRUMP
(gravely)
Young man, the turkey and I will negotiate.

7 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CVICU - NURSES' STATION - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 8:21 AM

Winston Teague (58), in a cardigan with a battery pack on his belt and a driveline taped under his shirt, sits in a wheelchair beside the nurses' station with a practice pad on his knees and a pair of wire brushes. Pauline (55) holds his coat. The nurses have gathered. Amond walks up with his discharge papers.

WINSTON
(to the nurses)
Fifteen days. (beat) You people kept me alive fifteen days and fed me Jell-O. (beat) This is what I can pay.

He plays. A soft, swinging brush pattern. The machine at his hip hums underneath it. The nurses laugh. One of them starts to sway. Amond stands very still.

PAULINE
(to Amond, quietly)
He hasn't played since March. (beat) He couldn't lift his arms in March.

AMOND
(beat)
His flows are five-point-four. His RV is holding. (beat) He's going home for Thanksgiving.

WINSTON
(still playing, to Amond)
June, Dr. Baker. (beat) Riverside Church. (beat) You're coming.

AMOND
(beat)
I don't usually go to weddings, Mr. Teague.

WINSTON
(finishing with a soft rimshot)
You're not usually the reason one happens.

Robert has stopped at the end of the hallway, watching. He catches Amond's eye and nods once.

8 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 8:47 AM

The kitchen is a war zone. Raven is elbow-deep in cornbread crumbs. The doorbell rings. She freezes, wipes her hands, and opens the door. Victor Donohue (72), silver-bearded, in a three-piece charcoal suit with a gold pocket watch chain across his vest, stands on the stoop with a white bakery box tied with string and a garment bag over his arm.

VICTOR
(warm, formal)
Dr. Ellison. (beat) I'm early. My driver said the Midtown Tunnel would be a disaster, so I left at seven-thirty. (beat) It was empty.

RAVEN
(barely)
Dr. Donohue. (beat) Good morning, sir.

VICTOR
(handing her the box)
Sweet potato pie. Make My Cake, St. Nicholas Avenue. (beat) I said I would arrive with a pie in my hands. I didn't say I would bake it. (beat) My wife made me promise that much honesty.

He steps inside, unzips the garment bag and takes out a crisp white chef's apron. He hangs his suit jacket on the newel post and ties the apron over his vest.

VICTOR
(rolling up his sleeves)
Now. (beat) Where do you want me?

RAVEN
(staring)
Sir, you don't have to...

VICTOR
(beat, gently)
Dr. Ellison. At Freedmen's Hospital in 1957, the residents cooked Thanksgiving for the patients whose families didn't come. (beat) I peeled four hundred potatoes. (beat) Hand me a knife.

Raven, dazed, hands him a paring knife and a sweet potato. He begins to peel in one long, perfect spiral.

9 INT. CLAYTON'S SUBLET - BROOKLYN HEIGHTS - KITCHEN - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 9:12 AM

A narrow galley kitchen. Remsen Street, a parlor-floor rental. Clayton (34), in a Harvard T-shirt, scrubs a turkey breast in the sink. Esther's single moving box sits on the counter, half unpacked: a cast-iron skillet, a Smilley's Hardware mug, a photo of five girls on a Mattapan stoop. Clayton's cell, on speaker, sits on the

counter.

CORINNE (V.O.)
(on speaker, a Boston voice like gravel)
...and you rub it with butter, under the skin, Clayton. Under. (beat) Not on top like you're polishing a car.

CLAYTON
(wrestling the bird)
Yes, Mrs. Smilley.

CORINNE (V.O.)
Is my daughter eating?

CLAYTON
(beat)
She's working until two. (beat) I'm on call. If L&D is quiet, I'll have this in the oven by three.

CORINNE (V.O.)
(beat)
There's going to be an empty chair at my table today, Clayton. (beat) Twenty-seven years, that boy has eaten at my table on Thanksgiving. He called last week and said no. (beat) I know why. (beat) I'm not asking you about it. (beat) I just want you to know there's an empty chair in Mattapan.

Clayton stands at the sink with butter on his hands, unable to answer.

CORINNE (V.O.)
(beat, softer)
You take care of my baby, Clayton. (beat) That's all I've ever asked anybody.

CLAYTON
(barely)
Yes, ma'am.

The line clicks off. Clayton looks at the photo of five girls on the stoop. The smallest one, Esther, is laughing on the shoulders of a gangly teenage boy. Malcolm.

10 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - BAY 4 - MORNING
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 9:58 AM

DEACON THEODORE "TEDDY" PRITCHARD (59), a big man in a church usher's suit with a carnation in his lapel, sits doubled over, sweating, gripping the rail. His wife HAZEL (57) stands beside him. Elxa, Marc and Esther are at the bedside.

HAZEL
The men's prayer breakfast at Antioch. (beat) Grits, sausage, three plates of pancakes. (beat) He threw up in the parking lot. Hard. (beat) Then he grabbed his chest and said something tore.

TEDDY
(gasping)
Like a zipper. (beat) Right down the middle.

Esther presses two fingers above his collarbone and stops.

ESTHER
(beat)
Crepitus. (beat) There's air under the skin of his neck.

Marc puts his stethoscope on Teddy's chest, listens, and his eyes go wide.

MARC
(quietly)
Crunching. With every heartbeat.

ELXA
(beat)
Hamman's crunch. Air in the mediastinum. (beat) Forceful vomiting, chest pain, subcutaneous emphysema. (beat) Mackler's triad.

ESTHER
(beat)
Boerhaave. (beat) He ruptured his esophagus.

ELXA
(already moving)
Chest X-ray. Gastrografin swallow. Pip-tazo and fluconazole. N.P.O., nothing, not even ice. (beat) Every hour counts. Past twenty-four hours, the mortality doubles. (beat) He needs a thoracotomy.

She stops. She looks at Marc. A thoracotomy is a chest case. A chest case is Cardiothoracic.

ELXA
(beat, to the nurse)
Page Dr. Bullock. (beat, then, evenly) Dr. Robert Bullock.

Marc stands at the bedside of the patient he just diagnosed and understands, all at once, that he's about to hand him away.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

11 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - RADIOLOGY - FLUOROSCOPY - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 10:31 AM

On the monitor: contrast trickles down Teddy's esophagus, then squirts out sideways through a gash in the left lower wall into the chest. Robert, in his scrubs and a cardigan, stands with Elxa, Marc, Esther and Amond.

ROBERT
(studying the film)
Left posterolateral wall. Two to three centimeters above the GE junction. (beat) Classic. (beat) Six hours old. That's early. That's lucky.

AMOND
Primary repair?

ROBERT
Two-layer primary repair, an intercostal muscle flap, and drainage. Left thoracotomy, seventh interspace. (beat) Dr. Baker, you're with me.

Marc steps forward on instinct. Robert looks at him. The whole room feels it.

ROBERT
(beat, quietly)
You can't, Marc.

MARC
(beat)
I know.

ROBERT
(beat)
You found it.

MARC
(beat)
Smilley found it. I heard it. (beat) Elxa named it.

ROBERT
(beat, holding his son's eyes)
Then I'll tell Deacon Pritchard who found it.

Robert walks out. Amond follows, glancing back at Marc.

ELXA
(beat, to Marc)
Leon Fairley in Bay 7 dropped a frozen turkey in hot oil on his driveway in Hollis. (beat) Go be a surgeon somewhere they'll let you.

12 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 6 - PEDIATRIC SUITE - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 10:49 AM

The lights are dim, and the laparoscopic monitors glow. Desmond, tiny under the drapes. Crump at the head, his bow tie tucked into his gown. Arianna holds the camera and a grasper.

CRUMP
(calm)
Elevate the appendix. Find the base. (beat) Dr. Cummings, what is the arterial supply of the appendix?

ARIANNA
(beat)
The appendiceal artery. A branch of the ileocolic. (beat) In the mesoappendix.

CRUMP
What drug is first-line for absence seizures in children?

ARIANNA
(beat, frowning)
Ethosuximide.

CRUMP
What's the most common cause of a painless lower GI bleed in a two-year-old?

ARIANNA
Meckel's diverticulum. (beat) Rule of twos. (beat) Amond had one. It nearly killed him in the middle of a CABG.

CRUMP
(beat)
You know all of it. (beat) Every answer. (beat) So why did you fail?

Arianna's hands freeze on the instruments.

ARIANNA
(beat, flat)
Who told you?

CRUMP
(beat)
Nobody, young lady. You just told me. (beat) Now staple the base.

She fires the stapler. The appendix comes free, swollen and purple but intact. Crump bags it.

CRUMP
(beat, quietly)
In 1971, I failed the written part of my surgical boards. (beat) A man from my own program stood in the hallway and said, "I told you so," loud enough to be heard on 135th Street. (beat) I passed the next year with the highest score in New York State.

ARIANNA
(beat)
What changed?

CRUMP
(beat)
I stopped taking the test as if he was grading it. (beat) You're not answering the questions, Dr. Cummings. You're answering your father. (beat) Answer the boy on the table.

13 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - BAY 7 - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 11:14 AM

LEON FAIRLEY (47), a big, sheepish man in a blackened Jets sweatshirt, sits with both forearms and hands wrapped in wet gauze. His eyebrows are gone. His brother-in-law DUANE (44), unharmed, stands guilty in the corner. Marc examines the burns. Kennerly, sent over by Gloria, gets the IV.

LEON
(miserable)
My wife said thaw it. (beat) I said a turkey's a turkey.

DUANE
I said thaw it too, Leon.

LEON
You handed it to me, Duane!

MARC
(unwrapping a forearm, gently)
Partial-thickness burns, both hands, both forearms. Blistering. Some deeper areas on the palms. Singed nasal hair. (beat) Mr. Fairley, any hoarseness? Trouble breathing?

LEON
(beat)
No. (beat) My eyebrows are gone, aren't they?

KENNERLY
(taping the IV)
They'll grow back. Your hands are the problem.

MARC
(to Kennerly)
Hands and a face flash. Burn center criteria, even under ten percent. (beat) Call Cornell. Weill Cornell Burn Center.

KENNERLY
(beat)
You call. (beat) They'll pick up faster for a Donohue.

A beat. Marc keeps dressing the burns.

MARC
(evenly)
Then call and say you're a Kennerly, and see how fast they pick up for that.

Kennerly looks at him. Then, strangely, he almost smiles. He picks up the phone.

KENNERLY
(dialing, low)
The Monopoly cards weren't me. (beat) For the record.

MARC
(beat, not looking up)
I know. (beat) You'd have used real money.

14 INT. A ROW HOUSE - CANARSIE, BROOKLYN - LIVING ROOM - DAY

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 11:42 AM

A crowded living room. Plastic slipcovers, a TV showing the end of the Macy's parade: wind whipping the balloons. A foldout couch with a neatly folded blanket on it. AUGUSTIN TOUSSAINT (64), a dignified, silver-haired Creole man, sits on the edge of the couch in a beautiful gray suit, slightly too loose on him now. Camille (29) stands in the doorway in her coat.

AUGUSTIN
(not looking at her)
I do not go to strangers' houses for a plate, Camille. (beat) I am not a charity.

CAMILLE
(beat)
Papa. It isn't charity. It's Thanksgiving. (beat) It's my friend's house.

AUGUSTIN
(beat)
Your friend from work.

CAMILLE
(beat)
Yes, Papa.

On the TV, the news anchor: "...high winds this morning, and the M&M's balloon struck a light pole in Times Square, injuring two sisters, police say..." Augustin turns it off.

AUGUSTIN
(quietly)
This suit is the only thing I have left from the house on Elysian Fields, Camille. (beat) I was wearing it to your mother's grave on the Friday before the storm. (beat) Monday, her grave was under eleven feet of water. (beat) I have worn it every day since. (beat) I do not want people to look at me and see a man who needs a plate.

CAMILLE
(kneeling in front of him)
Then let them see a man in a beautiful suit who came to dinner, Papa.

Augustin looks at his daughter for a long moment. He straightens his tie.

AUGUSTIN
(beat)
Is the food good at your friend's house?

CAMILLE
(smiling, eyes wet)
There's a girl from Savannah cooking it, Papa. With Victor Donohue.

AUGUSTIN
(beat, astonished)
The heart surgeon?

CAMILLE
Peeling potatoes.

15 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CAFETERIA - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 12:16 PM

The cafeteria is mostly empty, but Lillian's spread covers three tables. Miss Hattie (60) and Lillian serve side by side like old friends. Whitlow (56), in a cashmere overcoat, comes in for tea and stops, confused by the feast.

LILLIAN
(beaming)
Come on, baby. Everybody eats.

WHITLOW
(stiffly)
I'm just here for tea, madam.

LILLIAN
(already loading a plate)
Nobody comes into a building on Thanksgiving for tea. (beat) Turkey or ham?

WHITLOW
(beat)
I...

LILLIAN
Both. (beat) You look like a both.

She hands him the plate, heavy, steaming. Whitlow stands holding it. Miss Hattie, who knows exactly who he is, says nothing.

WHITLOW
(beat, stiff)
Thank you. (beat) Who should I... whom do I thank?

LILLIAN
Lillian Divine. (beat) Harmony's mother. The intern.

Whitlow's face does something complicated. Harmony is one of Marc's roommates. He nods, carries the plate to a corner table, sits down alone, and after a long moment, picks up his fork.

16 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - NURSES' STATION - DAY

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 1:58 PM

Elxa signs out to Esther at the counter. Mid-sentence, she stops, grips the counter edge, and breathes very carefully through her nose. Gloria, coming up from the ER with a plate of Lillian's food for her, sees it.

GLORIA
(setting down the plate)
Elxa.

ELXA
(through her teeth)
I'm fine.

GLORIA
(beat)
That's the third one I've watched you have since noon.

ESTHER
(turning, alarmed)
Third what?

ELXA
(beat, straightening, hand on her belly)
Braxton Hicks. (beat) It's nothing. I'm dehydrated, I'm twenty-nine weeks, and I've been on my feet for eleven hours.

GLORIA
(beat)
How far apart?

Elxa doesn't answer. Gloria waits. Gloria can wait longer than anyone alive.

ELXA
(finally, quietly)
Eight minutes.

Esther's face goes pale. Gloria is already reaching for the phone.

GLORIA
(into the phone)
L&D. (beat) Tell Dr. Hartwell I'm bringing him Dr. Bullock. (beat) The pregnant one.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

17 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - LABOR AND DELIVERY - TRIAGE 2 - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 2:21 PM

Elxa on the bed in a gown, two monitor belts around her belly. The tocometer draws gentle hills on the paper strip. Clayton, in scrubs, reviews the strip. Esther, now off shift in her street clothes, stands in the corner.

CLAYTON
Fetal heart rate one-forty, moderate variability, accelerations. (beat) Your son is having a better Thanksgiving than you are.

ELXA
(staring at the ceiling)
My son.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Your grandmother called it in the on-call room. I just read the ultrasound. (beat) Cervical length three-point-eight centimeters. Closed. Fetal fibronectin negative.

ESTHER
(quietly)
Negative means...

CLAYTON
(to Esther)
It means the chance she delivers in the next two weeks is under one percent. (to Elxa) You're dehydrated and you've been standing for eleven hours. (beat) A liter of fluid, two hours on the monitor, and you're going home with your feet up.

ELXA
(beat)
Don't call my mother.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Elxa. Your mother is the Chief of Obstetrics.

ELXA
(sitting up)
Exactly. (beat) She's at my brother's house for the first time in her life, with my grandfather, eating a Savannah girl's dressing. (beat) If you call her, she comes. (beat) Let her have one dinner.

Clayton looks at Esther. Esther looks at Elxa.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Two hours. (beat) If it changes, I call her. That's not negotiable.

18 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 2 - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 2:40 PM

Teddy Pritchard lies on his right side, his left chest open, the lung deflated. The esophagus lies exposed, a ragged two-and-a-half-centimeter tear in its wall. Robert holds the retractor. Amond sews the mucosa with fine absorbable suture.

ROBERT
Extend the myotomy until you see the whole mucosal tear. (beat) Leave the top of it and he leaks again on Sunday.

AMOND
(sewing)
Then the muscle layer. Then the intercostal flap.

ROBERT
(beat)
My mother taught me to knead rolls like this. (beat) Every fold matters, she'd say. A bad fold doesn't show until it's in the oven.

AMOND
(beat)
You made rolls?

ROBERT
Thirty-six of them. (beat) At five-thirty this morning. (beat) For my son's table. (beat) Don't tell anyone.

AMOND
(beat, tying)
Sir. (beat) My father died when I was nine. (beat) For seventeen years I didn't let my stepfather sit at the head of the table. (beat) I'm calling him today. Like I promised.

ROBERT
(beat, quietly)
Then call him from somewhere you can hear him, Dr. Baker. (beat) Not from a stairwell.

Amond finishes the last stitch. Robert inspects it.

ROBERT
(beat)
Good fold.

19 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 3:04 PM

The turkey is in the oven, golden through the glass. The kitchen smells like sage and butter. Victor, in his apron, his sleeves rolled up, sits at the table cutting cornbread into cubes with surgical precision. Raven stirs a pot of

giblet gravy.

VICTOR
(cutting)
Your hands are very steady, Dr. Ellison.

RAVEN
(beat)
I did hair to pay for college. (beat) Box braids at three in the morning. Seven hours, one head. (beat) If you shake, the part's crooked, and the lady never comes back.

VICTOR
(beat, smiling)
My Joan would have liked you. (beat) She operated standing on a crate at Harlem Hospital because the stools were for the men.

Raven laughs. Then she goes quiet, stirring.

RAVEN
(beat)
Dr. Donohue. Can I ask you something that isn't about surgery?

VICTOR
(setting down the knife)
That's my favorite kind.

RAVEN
(beat, not turning)
My mother has written me thirty-four letters. (beat) I opened one. Two weeks ago. (beat) It's Thanksgiving, and I don't know if I'm supposed to call her or if I'm supposed to let it be.

Victor is quiet for a moment.

VICTOR
(beat)
My father had a brother named Lucius. (beat) They quarreled in 1946 over a piece of land in Prince Edward County, Virginia. (beat) My father wrote him every Christmas for twenty-two years. (beat) Lucius died in 1968 with every letter in a drawer, unopened. (beat) My father said that was the worst day of his life, and he had buried a son.

Raven turns around.

VICTOR
(gently)
I'm a surgeon, Dr. Ellison. I don't believe in letting things be. (beat) I believe in finding out what's wrong while there's still time to do something about it.

20 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - PEDIATRIC RECOVERY - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 3:31 PM

Desmond, awake and sitting up in his Spider-Man pajamas, sips apple juice. Shonda dozes in the chair. Arianna sits on the edge of his bed, and Desmond holds the flashcards.

DESMOND
(reading carefully)
"Purple. Bio... sta-tis-tics." (beat) Why is it purple?

ARIANNA
Because purple is the color of suffering.

DESMOND
(giggling)
"What does... a P-value less than point-oh-five mean?"

ARIANNA
(beat)
It means if there were really no difference, you'd see a result like this less than five times out of a hundred. (beat) So it's probably not just luck.

DESMOND
(flipping the card, checking)
You got it right!

ARIANNA
(beat, softly)
Yeah. (beat) I always get it right when somebody's listening.

DESMOND
(beat)
Dr. Crump said you're going to be a doctor for kids.

ARIANNA
(beat, surprised)
He did?

DESMOND
He said you're mean like a lady who's nice inside. (beat) That's what my grandma is.

Arianna looks at the little boy. Then she takes the card back.

ARIANNA
(beat)
Next one, young man.

21 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ROOF - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 3:52 PM

Wind. The Manhattan skyline in the cold late-afternoon light. Amond stands by the helipad, his phone to his ear. Not the stairwell, so he can hear.

AMOND
(into the phone)
Hi. (beat) No. (beat) No, I don't want Mom yet. (beat) I called for you, Sol.

A long pause. On the other end, three thousand miles away, a man has stopped breathing.

SOLOMON (V.O.)
(on the phone, carefully)
Amond. (beat) Happy Thanksgiving, son.

AMOND
(beat)
I did a Boerhaave repair today. (beat) Esophageal rupture. Left thoracotomy, intercostal flap. (beat) I sewed the whole thing. (beat) I wanted to tell you first. (beat) Before her. Before anybody.

SOLOMON (V.O.)
(his voice breaking)
Why me?

AMOND
(beat)
Because you drove me to the science fair in 1990 and sat in the car for six hours, and I never said thank you. (beat) Because you've been sitting in the car for seventeen years, Sol.

Silence on the line. Then a sound in Los Angeles that might be a fifty-seven-year-old orthodontist crying in his kitchen.

SOLOMON (V.O.)
(beat)
Tell me about the flap.

Amond sits down on the edge of the helipad and tells him.

22 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - LABOR AND DELIVERY - TRIAGE 2 - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 4:20 PM

The IV bag is nearly empty. The hills on the tocometer have flattened. Esther sits beside Elxa with two plates of Lillian's food on her knees, foil peeled back.

ESTHER
(handing her a plate)
Turkey, collards, mac and cheese. (beat) And a slice of a pie that I think is legally a sedative.

ELXA
(taking it, eating, eyes closing)
Lillian Divine should run this hospital.

ESTHER
(beat)
Can I ask you something?

ELXA
(mouth full)
You're going to.

ESTHER
(beat)
How do you do it? (beat) Russell. Surgery. A baby. (beat) How do you keep a marriage alive when the hospital always wins?

Elxa stops chewing.

ELXA
(beat)
I don't know yet, Smilley. (beat) Russell signed us up for Lamaze on Monday nights. I'm on call Monday nights. (beat) I sat in this bed all afternoon thinking about how I didn't call him. (beat) I called you, Clayton and Gloria. (beat) I didn't call my husband.

ESTHER
(beat)
Call him now.

Elxa looks at her. Then she reaches for the phone on the wall and dials.

ELXA
(into the phone, her voice changing)
Russell. (beat) Baby, I'm okay. The baby's okay. (beat) But I need you to come get me.

23 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - FRONT HALL - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 4:41 PM

The doorbell. Marc, just home and still in his coat, opens it. Natasha stands on the stoop in a camel coat with a casserole dish. Robert, beside her, holds a covered basket of rolls as if it were a donor heart. A long, strange moment: the Chief of Surgery and the Chief of Cardio, on the stoop of their son's house.

MARC
(beat)
Hi.

NATASHA
(beat, smiling)
Hi, baby.

ROBERT
(holding up the basket)
Your grandmother's rolls.

They come in. Victor emerges from the kitchen in his apron, a dish towel over his shoulder. Natasha stops dead.

NATASHA
(beat)
Daddy. (beat) You're wearing an apron.

VICTOR
(serenely)
Dr. Ellison has put me to work. (beat) Natasha. (beat) Robert.

ROBERT
(beat)
Victor.

The two men shake hands. It lasts exactly one second longer than necessary. Raven appears behind Victor in her apron, flour on her cheek, and sees the Chief of Surgery and the Chief of Cardio in her front hall.

RAVEN
(faint)
Hello, Dr. Donohue. (beat) Dr. Bullock. (beat) Happy Thanksgiving. (beat) Excuse me.

She goes back into the kitchen. From inside comes the sound of someone sitting down very suddenly on the floor.

24 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - STOOP - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 5:02 PM

A yellow cab pulls up. GRACE BULLOCK (24), petite, in a Harvard Medical hoodie under a peacoat, a duffel on her shoulder, climbs out. She looks about sixteen. Marc comes down the steps two at a time and lifts her off the ground.

GRACE
(laughing)
Put me down! (beat) Put me down, I've been on the Acela for three and a half hours with a man who ate sardines!

MARC
(setting her down)
Gracie.

GRACE
(looking up at the house)
So this is it. (beat) Grandpa's secret house. (beat) Double-width brownstone, 1890s. (beat) Did you know Newtown Creek was the oil-refining capital of the country in the 1870s? Charles Pratt's Astral Oil Works, right across the creek. (beat) "The holy lamps of Tibet are primed with Astral Oil."

MARC
(dry)
Gracepedia.

Harmony comes up the sidewalk from the subway, still in her scrub pants, with two foil pans from her mother. She stops.

HARMONY
(beat)
You must be the good Bullock.

GRACE
(shaking her hand vigorously)
And you must be Double-O. (beat) He talks about you constantly. (beat) Is it true you sing like Mahalia Jackson? Mahalia was a contralto, you know. Most people think she was a soprano. (beat) Sorry. I do this. (beat) Hi.

HARMONY
(grinning, to Marc)
I love her.

MARC
(beat)
Everyone does. That's the problem.

25 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - LIVING ROOM - DAY
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 5:21 PM

Natasha sits on the arm of the sofa, finally relaxing, a glass of wine in her hand, watching Grace and Victor argue happily about a medical journal. Her cell phone buzzes. "QGH L&D." She answers.

NATASHA
(into the phone)
Donohue. (beat) Clayton. (beat) Happy Thanksgiving. (beat, her face changing) When? (beat) How far apart? (beat) Fibronectin? (beat) And she told you not to call me.

Robert, across the room, sees her face and sets down his glass.

NATASHA
(beat, standing)
No. You were right to call. (beat) I'm on my way.

She hangs up. The room has gone quiet.

MARC
Mama?

NATASHA
(calmly, picking up her coat)
Elxa had contractions this afternoon. (beat) They've stopped. The baby's fine. Clayton's sending her home. (beat) I'm going to look at the strip myself.

ROBERT
(already standing)
I'll drive.

NATASHA
(beat)
No. (beat) Stay. (beat, a look between them) Stay with your son, Robert. (beat) And with my father.

Robert looks at Victor. Victor looks at Robert. Natasha kisses Marc on the cheek and is out the door. The two men are left in the living room with nothing between them but a coffee table and twenty-seven years.

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

26 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - LABOR AND DELIVERY - TRIAGE 2 - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 5:58 PM

Natasha stands at the monitor, still in her coat, reading the paper strip fold by fold with her reading glasses on. Elxa sits up in bed. Esther stands by the window, holding her coat, ready to leave.

NATASHA
(reading)
Reactive. No decelerations. Contractions irregular and spacing out. (beat) Clayton read it correctly.

ELXA
(beat)
I told him not to call you.

NATASHA
(taking off her glasses)
I know. He told me. (beat) He told me that before he told me anything else. (beat) That's why I'll keep him.

ELXA
(beat, quietly)
You left Marc's dinner.

NATASHA
(sitting on the edge of the bed)
Thanksgiving, 1977. You were three months old. (beat) I was a junior at Radcliffe with two babies on my hip, and your father was at Howard. (beat) You had a fever of a hundred and three, and I sat in the emergency room at Mount Auburn Hospital all night. (beat) I missed your first Thanksgiving for you. (beat) I'll miss your brother's first one for you too.

ELXA
(beat, tears starting)
Two babies? (beat) Mama, I was the only...

NATASHA
(beat, smiling)
Your father counted as the other one.

Elxa laughs and cries at the same time. Esther moves toward the door, trying not to intrude.

NATASHA
(without turning)
Dr. Smilley.

Esther stops.

NATASHA
(beat)
Your husband's on call until midnight, and you're going home to a turkey breast in Brooklyn Heights. (beat) Come back to the house with me.

ESTHER
(beat)
Dr. Donohue, I don't think that's...

NATASHA
(standing, buttoning her coat)
Nobody eats alone on Thanksgiving, Dr. Smilley. (beat) Not at a table my father's sitting at.

27 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - FRONT HALL - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 6:07 PM

The doorbell. Harmony opens it. Camille stands on the stoop in a red wrap dress, holding a cast-iron pot with a dish towel. Beside her, in his beautiful gray suit, is Augustin, holding a bottle of wine in a paper bag as if it were a crown.

CAMILLE
(bright, a little too fast)
Hi! (beat) Papa, this is my friend Harmony. (beat) Harmony, this is my father, Augustin Toussaint.

HARMONY
(beat, swallowing "friend")
Mr. Toussaint. Welcome. (beat) Happy Thanksgiving.

AUGUSTIN
(bowing slightly, formal)
Mademoiselle Divine. Thank you for having an old man.

Victor appears in the hall in his vest, the apron finally off. The two old men see each other. Something passes between them, two patriarchs who have each built something and know what it costs.

VICTOR
(extending his hand)
Victor Donohue.

AUGUSTIN
(shaking it)
Augustin Toussaint. (beat) I know your name, Doctor. Everyone in New Orleans knows your foundation's name. You paid for the cardiac wing at Flint-Goodridge before it closed.

VICTOR
(beat)
And I know yours, sir. (beat) I stayed at the Hotel Toussaint on Esplanade in 1978, for a cardiology meeting. (beat) You sent champagne to every Black doctor in the building.

AUGUSTIN
(stopping, moved)
You remember that.

VICTOR
(beat)
I remember the men who sent champagne when other hotels wouldn't send towels. (beat) Come, Mr. Toussaint. Let me pour you a drink in my house.

He leads Augustin inside. Camille and Harmony, left in the hall, look at each other.

CAMILLE
(barely)
Thank you.

HARMONY
(beat, quiet)
"Friend."

CAMILLE
(beat)
Please, Choir. (beat) Not tonight.

28 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - TRAUMA 1 - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 6:31 PM

Paramedics rush in a tiny, elderly woman, MOTHER VIOLA STURDIVANT (84), in a church dress, blue around the lips, an EMT doing chest thrusts. Behind them, a frantic adult granddaughter. Kennerly and Gloria meet them. Dr. Fitch is across the room with a car crash.

EMT
Choked on turkey at the table, fifteen minutes ago. (beat) Family did the Heimlich, no luck. (beat) We couldn't get it with the bag.

KENNERLY
(grabbing the laryngoscope)
Magill forceps. Suction. (beat) Mrs. Sturdivant, stay with me.

He slides in the laryngoscope, lifts, and there it is: a thick bolus of turkey jammed above the vocal cords. Kennerly reaches in with the long, angled Magill forceps, grips it and pulls. Out comes a two-inch chunk of dark meat. Gloria suctions. Kennerly bags. One breath, two. Viola coughs. Her chest heaves. The blue fades from her lips. She gasps, then croaks:

VIOLA
(hoarse)
Who... who cooked that bird?

GRANDDAUGHTER
(sobbing, laughing)
Aunt Clarice, Grandma!

VIOLA
(beat)
Never again.

The trauma bay laughs. Kennerly sits back on his heels, sweating. Gloria disappears for a moment and comes back with a heavy foil-covered plate. She hands it to him.

GLORIA
(gruff)
Mrs. Divine left this for you. (beat) She said, "That boy eating by himself in the cafeteria looked hungry."

Kennerly looks at the plate. He knows exactly whose mother Mrs. Divine is.

KENNERLY
(barely)
She doesn't know who I am.

GLORIA
(beat, walking away)
She knows you were alone on Thanksgiving. (beat) That's all she needed to know.

29 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 6:52 PM

The football game is on the TV, Broncos and Cowboys, tied, heading to overtime. Robert sits at one end of the sofa, Victor in the armchair, Augustin between them with a bourbon. Grace sits cross-legged on the floor, reading a cardiology textbook.

AUGUSTIN
(to the TV, passionately)
The Saints are playing in San Antonio this year. (beat) San Antonio! (beat) A team without a city.

VICTOR
(beat)
A man without a city, Mr. Toussaint, is still a man.

Augustin goes quiet. Robert glances at Victor.

ROBERT
(beat, carefully)
Victor. (beat) Thank you for coming here. (beat) To his table.

VICTOR
(beat, eyes on the TV)
You've never thanked me for anything, Robert. (beat) Not for the wedding. Not for the fellowship at Hopkins I didn't arrange, which you assumed I had. (beat) Twenty-seven years.

ROBERT
(beat)
You never let me pay for anything I could thank you for.

A beat. Grace, on the floor, has stopped reading and is very still.

VICTOR
(beat)
That's fair. (beat) Thank you for your rolls, Robert. (beat) They're better than Josephine's. (beat) If you ever tell her I said that, I'll deny it under oath.

Robert stares at him. Then he laughs, startled, a real laugh. On the TV, the kicker hits the field goal in overtime. Broncos win. Augustin throws up his hands. Grace goes back to her textbook, smiling.

30 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - BACK PORCH - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 7:09 PM

The cold backyard. A string of Christmas lights someone put up too early. Raven sits on the porch steps in her apron with her phone in one hand and an envelope in the other. The return address: "L. ELLISON, MLK JR. BLVD., SAVANNAH, GA." She dials. It rings. Once. Twice.

LORNA (V.O.)
(on the phone, a soft Savannah voice, uncertain)
Hello?

Raven can't speak.

LORNA (V.O.)
(beat)
Hello? (beat) Who is this?

RAVEN
(barely)
Mama. (beat) It's Raven.

Silence on the line. A long one. Then a sound like a woman sitting down on a kitchen floor in Georgia.

LORNA (V.O.)
(beat, a whisper)
Raven. (beat) Baby. (beat) Oh, God. Oh, my God.

RAVEN
(crying)
Happy Thanksgiving, Mama. (beat) I'm cooking. (beat) I made Grandmother's dressing. (beat) I'm a doctor. I'm a surgeon. In New York.

LORNA (V.O.)
(crying)
I know, baby. (beat) I know. (beat) I've been reading about your hospital in the library. On the computer. (beat) I know everything. I just didn't know your voice anymore.

Raven pulls her knees up to her chest. Inside, through the kitchen window, Arianna sees her, sets down the flashcards and comes out to sit on the step beside her without a word.

RAVEN
(into the phone, shaking)
How many days, Mama?

LORNA (V.O.)
(beat)
One thousand and seventy-nine.

Raven closes her eyes. Arianna takes her free hand.

31 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - FRONT HALL - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 7:24 PM

The house is full: voices, laughter, the TV. The table is set in the dining room with mismatched chairs from every room in the house. Amond stands proudly beside a brand-new white porcelain gravy boat. The doorbell rings. Marc opens it.

Natasha stands on the stoop. Beside her, in her coat, holding a sweet potato pie still warm from Lillian's foil, is Esther.

NATASHA
(beat, lightly)
I found a stray.

Marc looks at Esther. Esther looks at Marc. Behind him, the house goes quiet. Harmony in the dining room doorway. Grace on the stairs. Raven and Arianna coming in from the porch, red-eyed. Victor in his vest, watching.

ESTHER
(beat, barely)
Your mother wouldn't let me eat alone.

MARC
(beat, stepping aside)
No. (beat) She doesn't do that.

Esther steps over the threshold into Marc's house on Thanksgiving.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

32 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - DINING ROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 7:38 PM

The long table, every chair in the house around it. The turkey, golden. Raven's Savannah dressing. Lillian's macaroni and cheese. Camille's gumbo. Robert's rolls. Victor's pie. Amond's gravy boat in the place of honor. Around the table: Victor at the head, Natasha and Robert, Grace, Marc, Esther, Raven, Arianna (her flashcards stacked beside her plate), Harmony, Camille, Augustin and Amond.

Victor rises. The table goes silent.

VICTOR
(bowing his head)
Lord. (beat) Thank you for the hands that made this food. (beat) Thank you for the hands at this table, which spend every day inside other people's lives. (beat) Keep them steady. (beat) And keep us humble enough to remember that every one of them was once held by somebody. (beat) Amen.

ALL
Amen.

GRACE
(immediately)
In my family, we go around and say what we're thankful for. (beat) It's a Donohue rule. It's been documented since 1962.

NATASHA
(dry)
It's been enforced since 1962.

GRACE
I'll go first. (beat) I'm thankful my brother finally told people who he is, so I could come to his house. (beat) And for Amtrak.

Laughter. It goes around the table.

AMOND
(beat)
I'm thankful for a man in Los Angeles who sat in a car for seventeen years. (beat) And a gravy boat.

ARIANNA
(beat, gruff)
Thankful for an eight-year-old who quizzed me on biostatistics. (beat) And for the person who made the cards.

RAVEN
(beat, her voice not quite steady)
I'm thankful I heard my mother's voice tonight. (beat) For the first time in six years.

A hush. Harmony reaches over and squeezes Raven's hand. Victor, at the head of the table, inclines his head to her.

AUGUSTIN
(rising slowly, glass in hand)
I am a guest. (beat) In August, I lost my hotel, my buildings, my wife's grave and my city. (beat) I was a man who sent champagne. Today I came to a stranger's house in my only suit. (beat) I am thankful to my daughter, who would not let me sit alone on a couch in Canarsie. (beat) And to her friend.

He nods to Harmony and sits. Camille is crying.

CAMILLE
(wiping her eyes, bright)
I'm thankful for my papa. (beat) And for my friend Harmony.

Harmony smiles. It costs her something. She looks down at her plate.

HARMONY
(beat, quietly)
I'm thankful for everybody who's somebody's friend.

Camille glances at her. Augustin, sipping his wine, watches them both.

ESTHER
(beat)
I'm thankful for a Chief who doesn't let people eat alone.

Natasha raises her glass a quarter inch.

NATASHA
(beat)
I'm thankful my daughter's son decided he's not in a hurry. (beat) And for Dr. Hartwell, who called me when he was told not to.

ROBERT
(beat, looking at Marc)
I'm thankful to be at my son's table. (beat) As his father. (beat) Out loud.

Marc looks at his father. Then it's his turn. He looks around the table: his family, the people who became his family, the woman he loves who is married to someone else.

MARC
(beat)
I'm thankful for the memories. (beat) All of them. (beat) Even the ones I'd take back.

Esther looks at her plate. Victor raises his glass.

VICTOR
(beat)
To the memories. (beat) May we make enough good ones to outnumber the rest.

ALL
To the memories.

33 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 8:29 PM

Harmony scrapes plates into the trash. Camille comes in with the empty gumbo pot and sets it down.

CAMILLE
(low)
Choir.

HARMONY
(not turning)
"My friend Harmony." (beat)
Twice. In front of Victor
Donohue.

CAMILLE
(beat)
He's sixty-four, Harmony. He lost
everything three months ago.
(beat) I can't take his daughter
away too.

HARMONY
(turning, quiet and
fierce)
You wouldn't be taking her away.
(beat) You'd be giving him all of
her.

Camille stares at her. Harmony goes back to the plates. Camille steps behind her and rests her forehead between Harmony's shoulder blades, just for a second.

The kitchen door swings open. Augustin stands there. He sees them. A long beat. Camille steps back too quickly.

AUGUSTIN
(evenly)
Camille. (beat) Dr. Ellison is
asking for the pie server.

CAMILLE
(beat)
Yes, Papa.

She grabs it from the drawer and goes. Augustin stays a moment longer, looking at Harmony with an expression that can't be read.

AUGUSTIN
(beat)
Your mother made the macaroni?

HARMONY
(barely)
Yes, sir.

AUGUSTIN
(beat, turning to go)
It was very good. (beat) Tell her an old man from New Orleans said so.

34 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - BACK PORCH - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 8:47 PM

The too-early Christmas lights. Marc on the steps with two slices of pie on paper plates. Esther comes out, her coat on, and sits a careful foot away. He hands her a plate.

ESTHER
(beat)
Your sister is a lot.

MARC
(beat)
She told you about Astral Oil?

ESTHER
(beat)
And the history of the Acela. (beat) And that you wet the bed at Martha's Vineyard until you were seven.

MARC
(closing his eyes)
Six.

Esther laughs. Then it fades.

ESTHER
(beat)
"Even the ones I'd take back." (beat) Is that me?

MARC
(beat)
No. (beat) The ones I'd take back are the ones where I lied to people I love. (beat) You were never one I'd take back, Esther.

She looks at him. In the window behind them, the warm, crowded dining room. Clayton's voice is nowhere in it.

ESTHER
(beat, standing)
I should go. (beat) Clayton gets off at midnight. (beat) I want to be there when he gets home.

MARC
(beat)
Yeah.

ESTHER
(beat, at the door, softly)
Thank you for letting it be, Marc. (beat) I know what it costs.

She goes inside. Marc sits alone with two pieces of pie.

35 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - STOOP - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 9:21 PM

A black Mercedes S-Class idles at the curb, its driver at the wheel. Victor, in his overcoat and fedora, comes down the steps with Marc at his elbow. He stops on the bottom step and looks back at the lit windows.

VICTOR
(beat)
Your grandmother called during the pie. (beat) Thirty-one Donohues at the table in Brookline. (beat) Claudette kept the peace. (beat) V.J. asked where I was. (beat) Joan told him I was "seeing to the future."

MARC
(beat, quietly)
Grandpa.

VICTOR
(beat)
Next Thanksgiving, I won't be able to come here as a man with a pie, Marc. (beat) Next year, everyone will know why I came.

Marc understands exactly what he means: the will, the sealed letter, the thing nobody at this table knows yet.

MARC
(beat)
They're my family too, Grandpa. (beat) The ones in there.

VICTOR
(looking at him, warm)
I know. (beat) That's the only reason I'm not afraid of it. (beat) Thank you for the memory, Marc-Anthony.

He gets into the Mercedes. It glides away down 49th Avenue. Marc stands on the stoop and watches the taillights until they're gone.

36 INT. THE DIVINE HOUSE - CAMBRIA HEIGHTS - KITCHEN - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 10:02 PM

A cozy kitchen, a family-sized mess of dishes. Jerry and Ronnie's voices come from the living room. Lillian washes. Howard dries. He coughs, the deep, wet cough, into a paper towel. He looks at it. It's clean. He folds it and puts it in his pocket.

LILLIAN
(not turning)
December eighth.

HOWARD
(beat)
December eighth, Lil.

LILLIAN
(beat)
Baby Girl looked at you this morning like a doctor.

HOWARD
(smiling, drying a plate)
She is a doctor. (beat) That's what we paid for.

Lillian turns off the water and stands with her wet hands on the sink, looking out the dark window. Howard puts his arms around her from behind.

37 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 10:38 PM

The kitchen is wrecked. Amond washes. Grace dries, still talking. The gravy boat, washed and gleaming, sits on the windowsill like a trophy.

GRACE
...and the first Macy's parade was in 1924, and they used live animals from the Central Park Zoo, and the balloons didn't come until 1927. (beat) Felix the Cat.

AMOND
(scrubbing)
Do you ever stop?

GRACE
(beat)
Not since 1985. (beat) I've been told it's exhausting. (beat) My last boyfriend said dating me was like dating a search engine.

AMOND
(beat, handing her a dish)
Search engines are useful.

Grace looks at him, pleased.

GRACE
(beat)
You bought a gravy boat for my grandfather.

AMOND
(beat)
I bought a gravy boat for this house. (beat) He was an excuse.

GRACE
(drying, smiling)
That's the most Donohue thing anybody's ever said to me.

38 INT. CLAYTON'S SUBLET - BROOKLYN HEIGHTS - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 11:16 PM

Clayton, still in scrubs under his coat, lets himself in. A lamp is on. Esther sits on the sofa under a blanket. On the coffee table: two plates of cold turkey breast, carved, and a foil-wrapped slice of pie from Queens.

CLAYTON
(beat)
You waited.

ESTHER
(beat)
You cooked. (beat) My mother told me you rubbed the butter under the skin.

CLAYTON
(sitting beside her)
She was very specific. (beat) How was it? The house.

ESTHER
(beat, honest)
Loud. Kind. (beat) Hard. (beat) I sat across the table from Marc and his whole family and I said thank you for the Chief. (beat) And all I could think about was my mother's empty chair.

Clayton is quiet.

ESTHER
(beat)
Next year, maybe we go to Mattapan. (beat) Both of us. (beat) And maybe there won't be an empty chair.

CLAYTON
(beat, carefully)
Maybe.

She takes a bite of cold turkey.

ESTHER
(beat)
It's dry.

CLAYTON
(beat)
It's been dry since four.

She laughs and leans her head on his shoulder. He leaves his arm around her.

END OF ACT FIVE

TAG

39 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - BREAK ROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 11:44 PM

Kennerly sits alone at the break room table with Lillian's foil plate in front of him: turkey, collards, macaroni and cheese and a hand-written note taped to the foil in round church-lady cursive: "Eat all of it. -Mrs. D." He eats slowly, like a man who hasn't had a home-cooked meal in a long time.

MARC (V.O.)
Doctors are trained to remember everything.

40 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - RAVEN'S ROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 11:52 PM

Raven in bed. Arianna asleep beside her, a flashcard still in her hand. On the nightstand: the red 30-day chip, and a phone number written on a napkin in Raven's hand: "MAMA." Raven looks at it for a long time. Then she turns off the lamp.

MARC (V.O.)
But the ones that matter don't stay in your head.

41 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - STOOP - NIGHT
THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2005 - 11:59 PM

Marc sits on the stoop in his coat. The street is empty. The Manhattan skyline blazes across the river. Behind him, the house is dark except for the kitchen, where Amond and Grace are still talking.

MARC (V.O.)
They live in your hands. In a pot of gumbo, a basket of rolls, a gravy boat on a windowsill.

He takes out his phone, scrolls to "GRANDMA," and presses call.

MARC
(softly)
Grandma. (beat) It's me. I know it's late. (beat) Daddy made your rolls. (beat) Grandpa said they were better than yours.

GRANDMA JO (V.O.)
(on the phone, wide awake, outraged)
He said WHAT?

Marc laughs into the cold night air.

MARC (V.O.)
Thanks for the memories.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE

Media Companion: Episode 2x09

Off-screen media around the episode, in chronological order. Not counted in page length (MA-009 §5).

ASSOCIATED PRESS: "WIND-WHIPPED BALLOON HITS LAMPPOST, INJURING 2 AT MACY'S PARADE"

Thursday, November 24, 2005

"NEW YORK (AP) -- A giant M&M;'s balloon struck a lamppost in Times Square during the Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade on Thursday, injuring two sisters, police said. The injuries were minor. Since a 1997 accident, the city has restricted balloon heights in high winds..."

THE DENVER POST (Sports): "BRONCOS TAKE TURKEY IN OT"

Friday, November 25, 2005

"IRVING, Texas -- Denver beat Dallas 24-21 in overtime on Thanksgiving Day on a field goal by Jason Elam..." Earlier, the Falcons beat the Lions, 27-7, in Detroit. The displaced Saints split their 2005 'home' games between San Antonio's Alamodome and Baton Rouge.

QueensGraceConfidential (Blogger)

Thursday, November 24, 2005, 3:12 PM

"HAPPY THANKSGIVING FROM THE FIFTH FLOOR. A certain intern's mother (the hat, the van, the PIES) fed the ENTIRE hospital again. Sources say even a certain Chief of Medicine ate a plate. Both turkey AND ham. Also: the Chief's son reportedly diagnosed a ruptured esophagus this morning and then had to hand the case to... his own father, per the Firewall. Imagine Thanksgiving dinner. Actually, don't. We hear the Old Man himself is AT that dinner. In an apron. We cannot confirm the apron. We are begging someone to confirm the apron." Comments (803).

Index card: "JO'S ROLLS" (Josephine Bullock's recipe, in her hand)

Written c. 1974; used November 24, 2005

"1 pkg yeast. 1/4 c warm water. 1 c scalded milk. 1/4 c sugar. 1/4 c Crisco. 1 egg. 4 c flour. Knead 10 min -- DON'T CHEAT, ROBERT. Rise 1 hr. Shape. Rise again. 400 degrees, 15 min. Brush with butter while hot."

Note taped to a foil plate (Lillian Divine)

Thursday, November 24, 2005

"Eat all of it. -Mrs. D."

SMS, Motorola RAZR (Harmony Divine to Raven Ellison)

Thursday, November 24, 2005, 11:58 AM

Harmony: "is victor really peeling potatoes"

Raven: "he does it in ONE PEEL. one. im going to faint"

Harmony: "dont faint on the turkey"

Continuity Sheet: Episode 2x09

New Canon Established

- **Thanksgiving at 49th Avenue:** Victor (head of the table), Natasha, Robert, Grace, Marc, Esther, Raven, Arianna, Harmony, Camille, Augustin and Amond, twelve in all. Victor arrived at 8:47 AM with a Make My Cake sweet potato pie (bought, not baked, per his promise) and a chef's apron, and cooked with Raven all day. Robert made Grandma Jo's rolls for the first time since Walter Bullock's funeral in 1999 (36 rolls). Amond bought a white porcelain gravy boat. Victor's toast: 'To the memories.'
- **Victor and Robert:** the first real thaw in 27 years. Victor: 'You've never thanked me for anything.' Robert: 'You never let me pay for anything I could thank you for.' Victor did *not* arrange Robert's Hopkins fellowship (Robert had assumed he did). Victor said Robert's rolls are 'better than Josephine's,' and Marc told Grandma Jo that night. Victor skipped the Brookline Thanksgiving (31 Donohues; Joan told V.J. he was 'seeing to the future'). On the stoop he told Marc: 'Next year, everyone will know why I came.' **The heir designation is still secret.**
- **Victor's family history:** his father's brother Lucius quarreled with Victor's father in 1946 over land in Prince Edward County, Virginia. His father wrote every Christmas for 22 years, and Lucius died in 1968 with the letters unopened. Victor's father had 'buried a son,' so Victor had a brother who died (details to come). At Freedmen's in 1957 Victor peeled 400 potatoes for patients' Thanksgiving. He stayed at the Hotel Toussaint in 1978, and Augustin sent champagne to every Black doctor there.
- **Raven called her mother.** Lorna Ellison (Savannah, MLK Blvd.) answered at 7:09 PM. It was the first time Raven had heard her voice in six years. Lorna has 1,079 days clean and follows QGH news on library computers. Raven said: 'I'm a surgeon. In New York.' Arianna sat with her. Raven has Lorna's number on her nightstand. Victor's advice ('I don't believe in letting things be') pushed her to call.
- **Elxa, 29 weeks:** contractions every 8 minutes from noon. Cervical length 3.8 cm, closed; fetal fibronectin negative; reactive strip. Diagnosis: dehydration and Braxton Hicks. One liter of fluid, then home with Russell. She told Clayton not to call Natasha, and he called anyway. Natasha left the dinner to read the strip herself, approved Clayton's read ('That's why I'll keep him') and brought Esther back to the house: 'Nobody eats alone on Thanksgiving.' Natasha's story: on Thanksgiving 1977 she sat all night at Mount Auburn Hospital with three-month-old Elxa, who had a fever of 103.
- **Harmony and Camille:** Augustin Toussaint (64) makes his on-screen debut. He's sleeping on a cousin's couch in Canarsie and wears his only surviving suit daily. He lost the house on Elysian Fields, the Hotel Toussaint on Esplanade and his wife's grave (under 11 feet of water). Camille introduced Harmony as 'my friend' twice. **Augustin walked in on a tender moment in the kitchen** and said nothing ('Tell her an old man from New Orleans said so'). Whether he knows is deliberately ambiguous.
- **Amond called Solomon first** ('I called for you, Sol'), from the roof, not a stairwell, as Robert advised. Solomon drove him to the 1990 science fair and waited six hours. Amond did the Boerhaave repair under Robert. **Marc diagnosed it but couldn't scrub** (Firewall). Robert:

'Then I'll tell Deacon Pritchard who found it.'

- **Arianna:** Crump quizzed her through an appendectomy: 'You're not answering the questions. You're answering your father.' Crump failed the written surgical boards in 1971 and passed the next year with the highest score in New York State. He told Desmond Royster that Arianna will be 'a doctor for kids' (foreshadowing her peds track). Desmond quizzed her with the purple cards.
- **Kennerly** pulled a turkey bolus from Viola Sturdivant's airway with Magill forceps. Lillian Divine left him a plate ('Eat all of it. -Mrs. D.'). Kennerly told Marc the Monopoly cards weren't him. Marc: 'You'd have used real money.' **Whitlow ate Lillian's food** in the cafeteria and learned she is Harmony's mother.
- **Howard Divine's CT is scheduled for December 8, 2005** at Jamaica Hospital (the 6 mm RUL nodule, per MA-005). His cough continues, with no blood. **Grace Bullock's on-screen debut** (24): Acela from Boston, 'Gracepedia' facts, and she bonds with Amond over dishes. Clayton and Esther talked about going to Mattapan next year 'if there won't be an empty chair.' Winston Teague went home on day 15 and played brushes for the CVICU; Amond is invited to the June wedding.

Knowledge Tracker (as of November 24, 2005)

Item	Who knows
Heir designation	Still secret: Victor, Marc, V.J. (not the content), the Foundation board, Natasha and Joan
Harmony and Camille are together	The housemates, Grace (likely), Augustin (ambiguous)
Raven called her mother	Arianna; the whole table (Raven's toast)
Elxa's contraction scare	Natasha, Robert, Clayton, Esther, Gloria, Russell, the table
Howard's nodule / CT date	The Divines, Harmony

Patient Registry

Patient	DOB / age	Diagnosis	Procedure / surgeon	Outcome
Deacon Teddy Pritchard	4/9/1946 (59)	Boerhaave syndrome (2.5 cm distal left tear) after a prayer breakfast	Left thoracotomy, two-layer repair, intercostal flap (R. Bullock; Baker)	Repaired within 6 hours; good prognosis
Desmond Royster	2/19/1997 (8)	Acute appendicitis (Alvarado 8), non-perforated	Laparoscopic appendectomy (Crump; Cummings)	Recovering
Leon Fairley	7/16/1958 (47)	Partial-thickness burns, both hands and forearms, facial flash (frozen turkey in a fryer)	Stabilized (Bullock; Kennerly)	Transferred to Weill Cornell Burn Center
Mother Viola Sturdivant	9/12/1921 (84)	Supraglottic food bolus obstruction (turkey)	Laryngoscopy, Magill forceps extraction (Kennerly)	Revived: 'Never again'
Dr. Elxa Bullock	8/29/1977 (28)	Contractions at 29w0d; dehydration	IV fluids, monitoring (Hartwell; Donohue reviewed)	FFN negative; discharged home

Patient	DOB / age	Diagnosis	Procedure / surgeon	Outcome
Winston Teague	1/22/1947 (58)	LVAD destination therapy, post-op day 15	Discharge (Baker)	Home for Thanksgiving

New Characters

- **Augustin Toussaint** (b. February 9, 1941), on-screen debut. **Lorna Ellison** (b. March 14, 1961), voice debut; she had Raven at 18. **Grace Bullock**, on-screen debut (in MA-005).
- **Deacon Teddy Pritchard** (b. April 9, 1946, Antioch Baptist usher) and **Hazel** (b. January 30, 1948). **Desmond Royster** (b. February 19, 1997) and **Shonda** (b. June 2, 1974). **Leon Fairley** (b. July 16, 1958) of Hollis and **Duane** (b. March 5, 1961). **Mother Viola Sturdivant** (b. September 12, 1921).

Real-World Accuracy Notes

- On Thanksgiving, November 24, 2005, high winds at the Macy's parade drove the M&M;'s balloon into a Times Square lamppost, injuring two sisters (minor injuries). The Broncos beat the Cowboys 24-21 in overtime, and the Falcons beat the Lions 27-7. The displaced 2005 Saints played home games in San Antonio and Baton Rouge. The first Macy's parade (1924) used Central Park Zoo animals, and balloons began in 1927 with Felix the Cat. Charles Pratt's Astral Oil Works stood on Newtown Creek ('The holy lamps of Tibet are primed with Astral Oil'). Flint-Goodridge Hospital in New Orleans closed in 1983. Make My Cake is a Harlem bakery.
- Medicine: Boerhaave syndrome (spontaneous transmural esophageal rupture, usually distal left posterolateral) presents with Mackler's triad (vomiting, chest pain, subcutaneous emphysema) and Hamman's crunch, and is confirmed by a water-soluble contrast swallow. Repair within 24 hours (two-layer closure with a muscle flap through a left thoracotomy) greatly lowers mortality. A negative fetal fibronectin has a very high negative predictive value (about 99%) for delivery within 14 days. Hand and face burns meet burn center referral criteria regardless of %TBSA. A supraglottic food bolus is removed with Magill forceps under direct laryngoscopy. The Alvarado score is used for appendicitis.